CHAPTER 3

THE ANNOUNCEMENT

11 May 2024, 2:08pm

A month passes, maybe more. I have kept it to myself. Nobody knows but Daniella, Gaz and Dave still. They are still angry on my behalf. I am at Trent Bridge in Nottingham with Lancashire as they play a County Championship game and I am preparing for my 188th and last England game, a fate that no one yet knows about. The retirement question is still routine daily interaction as, in some sort of new dissonance, my inner world completely disassociates from the outside. I remember this feeling; it's like being at school. I'm alone with my own reality and no one to share it with. England media manager, Danny Reuben, phones me. There's an urgency in his voice, one laced with that same reticence, dread and self-protection as the tone in that bar. The news of the retirement has been leaked, he tells me. Ali Martin has heard about it and would like to call me. I get the call at 2:08pm. 'Jimmy, I've heard that Brendon McCullum has flown over from New Zealand to tell you that the Test team are looking to the future and you'll be playing your last game this summer. I'm sorry, but it's an unignorable story.' At the end of the tour, McCullum's answer to Martin's question on my chances of making the next Ashes suddenly flicks back into my mind. 'I don't know, honestly,' McCullum had said then, 'who knows where the end of the line for him is?' It's all starting to slowly fall into place. I understand, I tell Ali. We've known each other 15 years. This is his job. It's done swiftly, amicably, I just ask how long I have until the *Guardian* prints it. He texts me soon after, at 2:30pm, saying his office have said it will go out at 5pm. I have a few hours before it's going to be announced to tell whoever I need to tell.